



PART OF STATES NEWSROOM

NM Legislature 2025 | Track the bills that matter to you with SOURCE NM'S BILL TRACKER.

ENVIRONMENT & CLIMATE CHANGE

BRIEFS

State extinguishes Gallup-area mine fires burning since at least 2011

BY: **PATRICK LOHMANN** - OCTOBER 22, 2024 4:45 AM

📷 An employee with Runyan Construction takes a temperature reading of a Gallup-area coal mine fire that's been burning since for at least 13 years. State officials announced Monday that two mine fires burning since at least 2011 were extinguished. (Photo courtesy EMNRD)

UPDATE Oct. 22 at 3:44 p.m.

According to Mike Thompson, manager of the EMNRD Abandoned Mine Land Program, there are at least five other coal mine fires burning in New Mexico today, in addition to the two that were extinguished recently.

Two are near La Plata, known as the Jones Mine Fire and the Van Houten Fire. There's another near Waterflow in northwestern New Mexico. And there are two others very close to the ones in Gallup that were extinguished.

"None will be as easy as these were," Thompson said in an email. "Coal mine fires are typically too deep to dig up or are located in very inaccessible terrain. It is almost impossible to smother the fire from the surface."

That goes for the two remaining fires in Gallup. "Again, we are studying our options but the two left in Gallup would be very difficult to extinguish," he said.

The fires spew toxic fumes and have been burning for years, in some cases. Thompson discouraged members of the public from seeking them out.

See below for a map of ongoing coal mine fires in New Mexico.

Two fires burning in abandoned coal mines since at least 2011 – and possibly much longer – were finally extinguished near Gallup recently, thanks to a dedicated

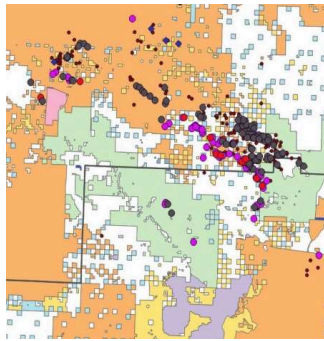
effort by a state team and federal funding, officials announced Monday.

The two underground coal fires were emitting toxic gas near the site of planned infrastructure projects, including a major water pipeline. The mines were first established in the late 1800s and operated until the early 1900s, according to a news release from the state Energy, Minerals and Natural Resources Department.

In 1891, a fire broke out near one of the mines, called “Navajo No. 1,” and the mine was sealed in 1905 as a result, according to the news release. But it’s unclear from state records whether sealing the mine actually extinguished the fire, spokesperson Sidney Hill said.

More than 100 years later, staff from the state’s Abandoned Mine Land Program encountered fires at that mine and at a separate mine, known as “Enterprise-Brown.” That was in 2011.

A problem of ‘infinite scope and cost’



A bill invigorating New Mexico government to coordinate the cleanup of abandoned uranium mines passed both chambers of the Legislature this session, but the state will confront a decades-old problem that experts say has a potentially “infinite” scope and cost. Sen. Jeff Steinborn (D-Las Cruces)

sponsored the “Uranium Mine Cleanup” bill, one that will mobilize ... Continue reading



Source New Mexico

0

After the fires were discovered, team members monitored the mines for several years before devising a plan to extinguish them, thanks, in part, to funding from the federal Bipartisan Infrastructure Law.

The law sets aside about \$12 billion for abandoned mine remediation across the country, including roughly \$36 million to New Mexico over the next 15 years. Extinguishing these fires cost about \$385,000, according to the news release.

The “Enterprise-Brown” fire was burning toward the Navajo Gallup Water Supply Line, a huge project carrying water through 300 miles of pipeline from the San Juan River to the eastern edge of the Navajo Nation, part of the Jicarilla Apache Nation and the city of Gallup.

The “Navajo No. 1” fire was burning near a new recreation area planned for campers and hikers, according to the news release.

Temperatures from both fires reached 500 degrees Fahrenheit in some places, Hill said. The team used specialized drilling equipment and seismic surveys to determine the fires’ spread.

Then they used heavy equipment to dig out coal seams where the fire was burning, which was then filled. After both seams were filled with a “benign material” and temperatures fell to 90 degrees, the sites of both mines were covered with native seeds and wood mulch, Hill said.

The mine fires posed risks not only to the infrastructure project but also could have sparked a wildfire, EMNRD Secretary Melanie Kenderdine said in the news release.

Ongoing mine fires in New Mexico



According to the state Energy, Minerals and Natural Resources Department, five coal mine fires are burning in New Mexico right now. Two near Gallup were extinguished recently, but two others remain and "would be very difficult to extinguish," based on the terrain and how deep the fires are, according to state officials.



REPUBLIC

Our stories may be republished online or in print under Creative Commons license CC BY-NC-ND 4.0. We ask that you edit only for style or to shorten, provide proper attribution and link to our website. AP and Getty images may not be republished. Please see our [republishing guidelines](#) for use of any other photos and graphics.

**PATRICK LOHMANN**

Patrick Lohmann has been a reporter since 2007, when he wrote stories for \$15 apiece at a now-defunct tabloid in Gallup, his hometown. Since then, he's worked at UNM's Daily Lobo, the Albuquerque Journal and the Syracuse Post-Standard.

Source New Mexico is part of [States Newsroom](#), the nation's largest state-focused nonprofit news organization.

MORE FROM AUTHOR

MORE FROM OUR NEWSROOM

GAO-23-105408

Biden signs law to clean up abandoned mines across the western U.S.BY **DANIELLE PROKOP**

December 18, 2024

**A fossil fuel group is working with US tribes to boost LNG exports**BY **HILARY BEAUMONT, FLOODLIGHT**

November 14, 2024

SCRAPPY INDEPENDENT JOURNALISM FOR YOU**DEMOCRACY TOOLKIT**



Come to Source NM for fresh reporting, insightful opinion and analysis from around the state. We're here to serve you. We're your resource.

We're part of States Newsroom, the nation's largest state-focused nonprofit news organization.

[DEIJ Policy](#) | [Ethics Policy](#) | [Privacy Policy](#)

REPUBLIC

Our stories may be republished online or in print under Creative Commons license CC BY-NC-ND 4.0. We ask that you edit only for style or to shorten, provide proper attribution and link to our website. (See full republishing guidelines.)



© Source New Mexico, 2025

v1.73.0

STATES NEWSROOM

FAIR. FEARLESS. FREE.